The Franciscan Kitchen

IT Strategic Assessment Report

4/25/2026

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary 3

2. History and Purpose 4
   - 2.1 History of the Franciscan Kitchen 4
   - 2.2 Purpose of the Franciscan Kitchen 5

3. Management and Business Processes. 5
   - 3.1 Practice 1: Meal Planning, Preparation, and Food Safety 6
   - 3.2 Practice 2: Meal Service Delivery and Guest Flow Management 6
   - 3.3 Practice 3: Volunteer Recruitment, Scheduling, and Coordination 7
   - 3.4 Practice 4: Donations Intake, Purchasing, and Inventory Management 8
   - 3.5 Practice 5: Administration, Communication, and Reporting 8

4. Current IT Environment 9
   - 4.1 Hardware 9
   - 4.2 Software 9
   - 4.3 Staff IT Skills/Training 10
   - 4.4 IT Budgeting and Spending 11

5. Envisioned IT Capabilities 11
   - 5.1 Leadership's Vision 11
   - 5.2 Top 10 Technology Issues 12

6. Closing the Gap 14
   - 6.1 Recommendation 1: Consolidate Volunteer and Contact Data into One System of Record (LGL) 14
   - 6.2 Recommendation 2: Unify Volunteer Scheduling and Reduce Manual Follow-up 15
   - 6.3 Recommendation 3: Improve Communication and Engagement with Younger Supporters 15
   - 6.4 Recommendation 4: Create Lightweight Metrics and Reporting That Preserve the Mission 16
   - 6.5 Recommendation 5: Plan for Hardware Refresh and Basic Security Continuity 17

7. Conclusion 17

8. Appendices 18
   - 8.1 Basis of Analysis 18
   - 8.2 Technology Inventory 19
   - 8.3 Top 10 Technology Issues 19

1. Executive Summary

This IT Strategic Assessment reviews the Franciscan Kitchen's current technology environment and identifies practical improvements that fit the organization's "keep it simple" approach. The Kitchen uses a small set of tools to support administration, donors, volunteers, and accounting, including SignUpGenius, Little Green Light (LGL), Google Drive, and QuickBooks.

Key opportunities include consolidating volunteer and contact information into a single system of record, reducing duplicate volunteer scheduling methods, strengthening digital communication to reach younger supporters, creating lightweight impact metrics that do not add burden to guests, and planning for basic hardware refresh and continuity.

2. History and Purpose

2.1 History of the Franciscan Kitchen

The Franciscan Kitchen has a long operating history in the Louisville community and is currently in its 46th year of service. Over time, the organization has maintained a consistent focus on direct meal service rather than expanding into broader social service programming. Leadership described the organization as intentionally simple in both mission and operations, emphasizing that the Kitchen's core role is to provide meals without additional requirements placed on guests.

From an operational perspective, leadership described the Franciscan Kitchen as a roughly million-dollar operation supported entirely through private contributions rather than government funding. Support comes through both financial donations and contributed food. Leadership noted that contributed food represents a significant portion of the organization's resources and can include a wide variety of items, from non-perishables to perishable donations from events or partner organizations.

The organization's staffing model also reflects its community-based roots. Leadership stated they have six part-time staff members and that the remainder of operations are supported by volunteers. This combination of long-term service history, private support, and volunteer-driven operations shapes how the Kitchen approaches technology and process improvements, with an emphasis on practicality and sustainability.

2.2 Purpose of the Franciscan Kitchen

The Franciscan Kitchen's purpose is straightforward and consistently communicated by leadership: "feed the hungry." This purpose is carried out through a no-questions-asked approach in which guests are able to come in, select what they would like to eat, and receive a meal without being screened or required to provide personal information. Leadership specifically noted that the Kitchen is not structured like a social service organization that quantifies and collects detailed data about the people it serves.

This model aligns the Kitchen's purpose with dignity and accessibility. It prioritizes immediate community need and reduces barriers for guests, while also keeping operations focused on meal service rather than case management. Leadership acknowledged that this approach can create limitations in certain funding situations when external funders request demographic or impact reporting, but they also emphasized that the Kitchen has been able to operate successfully without shifting away from its core purpose.

3. Management and Business Processes.

The Franciscan Kitchen's core operations revolve around preparing and serving meals consistently, safely, and respectfully. Because the organization depends on a mix of staff, volunteers, and donated resources, the most important management challenge is coordination. Even small changes for any of those can significantly affect meal production and the experience of those involved. The following practices represent the major business processes that enable the Kitchen to deliver its mission.

3.1 Practice 1: Meal Planning, Preparation, and Food Safety

Meal planning and preparation is the foundational process that supports daily service. Leadership must plan meals based on expected demand, available ingredients, and storage capacity, while also changing plans based on donations and supply availability. Planning decisions directly influence purchasing, volunteer task assignments, preparation timelines, and the ability to run service without disruption.

Food safety must be integrated throughout this process, including sanitation, proper storage and rotation, labeling, and safe temperature control from preparation to holding and service. Since volunteers might have different experience levels, the Kitchen's ability to standardize procedures and communicate expectations plays a major part in keeping operations safe and efficient. This practice is successful when meal production can be completed on time with consistent quality, minimal waste, and when safety practices are repeatable regardless of who is on site.

3.2 Practice 2: Meal Service Delivery and Guest Flow Management

Meal service is the core process and requires both operational efficiency and strong coordination. The service workflow typically includes setting up the serving area, distributing meals with consistency, maintaining cleanliness, and managing guest flow so that the environment remains safe and organized. Service also depends on coordination between food production and the distribution area so that food is replenished and held appropriately

throughout the serving period.

This practice is successful when meals are served smoothly and efficiently, and when staff and volunteers can maintain a respectful and consistent guest experience. Common challenges in similar service models include unclear role coverage, inconsistent communication between kitchen and service areas, and limited ability to forecast demand from day to day. These details will be explored further through continued discussion with Kitchen leadership.

3.3 Practice 3: Volunteer Recruitment, Scheduling, and Coordination

Volunteer coordination is a critical business process because volunteer availability directly affects the Kitchen's ability to prepare and serve meals. The process generally includes outreach and recruitment, collecting volunteer availability, scheduling and confirmations, and day-of coordination. The Franciscan Kitchen publicly references using a volunteer scheduling tool, which suggests volunteer work is organized through a structured sign-up process rather than informal coordination.

Volunteer orientation and training are also part of this practice. Even when training is lightweight, volunteers need consistent guidance related to safety, cleanliness, and role-specific expectations. This practice is successful when shifts are consistently filled, volunteers arrive prepared, and roles are assigned in a way that prevents bottlenecks. The major risks in volunteer-driven operations include last-minute cancellations, uneven distribution of skills, and knowledge around operations that is not documented or consistently and clearly communicated.

3.4 Practice 4: Donations Intake, Purchasing, and Inventory Management

The Kitchen's ability to operate consistently depends on a continuous cycle of taking in donations, purchasing goods, and managing inventory. Donations and purchased supplies must be received, checked, stored, and then made visible for planning. Because the volume and type of donations can fluctuate, reliable inventory awareness is needed so leadership can decide when to adjust menus, substitute ingredients, or purchase items to maintain service.

This practice is successful when incoming donations can be quickly converted into usable inventory, when critical supplies are reliably available, and when waste is minimized through storage rotation. Complexity often arises from inventory tracking spread across multiple methods or people, limited visibility into current stock levels, and incomplete donation logging. These potential pain points will be validated during interviews and workflow review.

3.5 Practice 5: Administration, Communication, and Reporting

Administrative coordination supports daily execution and long-term sustainability. This includes communication between leadership, staff, and volunteers, maintaining policies and procedures, tracking operational outcomes, and producing reports for internal and external stakeholders

Because organizations often rely on a small set of staff and key volunteers, the quality of documentation and important information becomes a major factor in continuity. This practice is

successful when information is easy to retrieve, procedures are repeatable, and leadership can plan based on trends rather than just immediate needs. When this practice is weak, it tends to increase workload, create duplicated effort, and make improvement initiatives harder to both implement and sustain.

4. Current IT Environment

4.1 Hardware

The Franciscan Kitchen's hardware footprint is small and focused on basic office and administrative needs. Staff described using an executive director desktop computer and laptops for other staff members. The laptops are generally older (five years or more), but they are still functional for daily work.

In addition to staff computers, the organization uses standard office equipment such as donated printers and a scanner. They also maintain a security camera system that is separate from staff laptops, with cameras connected to a screen so staff can monitor multiple areas of the property. Finally, the organization recently upgraded its phone system and described it as a meaningful improvement over the prior system.

Overall, their hardware environment supports current operations without a large amount of infrastructure. The main limitation noted is aging equipment, which may become a future replacement need even if it is not currently causing major disruption.

4.2 Software

The Franciscan Kitchen relies on a small set of core tools that support donor management, volunteer scheduling, accounting, and basic office productivity. Staff stated they use Windows and "regular office type stuff," along with Google tools and files stored in Google Drive.

For volunteer scheduling, they use SignUpGenius. Volunteer opportunities are posted and individuals sign up for available time slots. At the same time, the organization also maintains a paper calendar for some long term volunteers, meaning two parallel scheduling methods are used depending on the volunteer group. Staff shared that SignUpGenius works well overall, but volunteer reliability matters, and they sometimes call larger groups ahead of time to confirm attendance because meal service depends on adequate volunteer coverage.

For donor management, the organization uses Little Green Light (LGL), described as a CRM style database. Leadership indicated LGL has improved their ability to track donor giving and donor history. Staff also described an ongoing effort to consolidate volunteer and contact lists currently stored in Google Drive into LGL so that the system is used more fully and information is less scattered.

For accounting, they use QuickBooks. For payments, they use Square for events, and they accept credit card donations through their website. Staff stated the website is hosted through eCatholic, and donation receipts were noted as coming from BluePay, suggesting that multiple vendors may be involved in supporting online donations.

4.3 Staff IT Skills/Training

Technology use at the Franciscan Kitchen appears to be supported through practical experience rather than formal training. Staff described a model where specific individuals understand specific systems, and they work together based on that knowledge.

When issues arise, the organization has an outside company they can contact, but they often rely on internal support first. Staff mentioned that some volunteers and board members have IT backgrounds, and there is at least one volunteer who checks in regularly and helps troubleshoot issues such as office equipment problems (for example, a scanner). This informal support structure helps keep technology running without requiring dedicated full time IT staffing.

Because staffing is limited and many roles are part time, recommendations that require ongoing maintenance, frequent troubleshooting, or significant training may be harder to sustain. Improvements that simplify workflows and reduce duplication are likely to fit better with the organization's capacity.

4.4 IT Budgeting and Spending

The Franciscan Kitchen's approach to budgeting is based on reviewing prior years, identifying upcoming needs, and allocating spending accordingly. Staff described using historical spending as a baseline, adjusting based on expected needs, and then presenting the budget to the board for review.

In addition to standard budgeting, leadership described how donor relationships can enable larger upgrades when a need arises. Rather than planning every technology upgrade far in advance, they may reach out to donors who are willing to fund specific items, such as a phone system upgrade or potentially new laptops. This reflects a relationship driven model for covering larger expenses when needed.

Oversight for spending and operations is provided through a board of directors that meets every two months and reviews finances and operations. Leadership noted that the board may ask for assessments of how tools and investments are working, although they do not typically quantify return on investment in a strict monetary way.

5. Envisioned IT Capabilities

5.1 Leadership's Vision

Leadership emphasized keeping operations simple and avoiding extra administrative work that does not directly support the mission. They described the organization's mission as "feed the hungry" with a no questions asked approach, and they noted that they do not operate like a social service organization that collects extensive client demographics. Leadership recognizes that this can be a weakness when

approaching certain funders who want demographic reporting, but they also stated that the organization has been able to operate successfully without detailed data collection.

Within that simplicity focused mindset, leadership expressed a clear interest in strengthening communication and relationships, especially to support long term sustainability. A major theme from the meeting was the need to reach younger generations more effectively. Leadership noted that the organization is largely supported by older volunteers and donors, and they want to expand beyond traditional communication methods such as paper newsletters to build engagement with younger community members who could become future volunteers and donors.

Leadership also described a desire to better integrate and centralize their information systems. They view Little Green Light as a valuable tool for donor management and are working to move additional lists currently stored in Google Drive into the CRM so it can serve as a more complete system of record. They also mentioned continuing to work out “kinks” related to volunteer and donor information and how communication platforms integrate.

Finally, leadership acknowledged that emerging technology topics such as AI exist and may need to be addressed eventually, but they did not frame AI adoption as an immediate priority. Their vision centers on practical improvements that make communication stronger, reduce duplication, and improve continuity without adding heavy operational overhead.

5.2 Top 10 Technology Issues

The Franciscan Kitchen’s technology environment is intentionally simple, but the meeting surfaced several areas where processes and systems create extra coordination work or introduce continuity risk. Below are the top technology issues identified from the initial stakeholder discussion.

1. **Limited service demographic data for external funders.** Leadership noted they do not collect detailed client demographics and often rely on estimates, which can make some funding conversations harder when foundations ask for demographics and reporting.
2. **Volunteer scheduling is split across SignUpGenius and a paper calendar.** The Kitchen uses SignUpGenius for many volunteers but also keeps a separate paper calendar for long-time volunteers, which prevents a single complete view of coverage.
3. **Volunteer attendance is a reliability risk that requires manual follow-up.** Staff shared that if larger groups do not show up, meal service can be impacted, and they sometimes call groups ahead of time to confirm they are still coming.
4. **Volunteer and contact lists are distributed across Google Drive rather than centralized.** Staff described having multiple lists stored in Google Drive and an active effort to consolidate information into Little Green Light so it can serve as a more complete system of record.
5. **Little Green Light is valuable but not yet being used to its full capability.** Leadership described that LGL works well and has improved donor tracking, but they are still working out kinks with volunteer and donor information and communication platform integration.
6. **Inventory visibility depends heavily on key people rather than a shared system.** Staff stated that inventory management is largely held in the executive director's knowledge, supported by the warehouse manager handling stocking and rotation. This can create continuity risk when key people are unavailable.
7. **Donation intake is complex, and tracking is limited to broad measures rather than item-level detail.** The Kitchen receives food through many sources (pickups, partner deliveries, and purchases), and leadership described donation tracking as weight-based

rather than itemized, due to the time and staffing it would require.

8. **Online donations and event payments involve multiple vendors, which can complicate troubleshooting and reporting.** The website is hosted by eCatholic, receipts were noted as coming from BluePay, and Square is used for events, creating a multi-tool payment environment.
9. **Aging staff laptops create future reliability and security risk.** Staff indicated most laptops are five years old or older. While functional today, older hardware typically increases the risk of downtime and replacement needs.
10. **IT support is informal and dependent on volunteer availability.** The Kitchen has an outside IT contact, but often relies on board members and volunteers (including one who checks in regularly) for troubleshooting before reaching out for paid support.

6. Closing the Gap

6.1 Recommendation 1: Consolidate Volunteer and Contact Data into One System of Record (LGL)

The first recommendation is to reduce the number of separate lists used for volunteers and contacts and fully consolidate that information into Little Green Light (LGL). Staff noted that LGL is already used successfully for donor management and that the organization is actively working to move volunteer and “people” lists out of Google Drive and into LGL so the tool can serve its full purpose.

This recommendation directly supports operational continuity without adding complexity. When lists are spread across Google Drive files, it becomes harder to ensure data stays current, and it increases the chance of duplicated outreach, missed follow-ups, or inconsistent contact information. A single system of record makes it easier to segment audiences (donors vs volunteers vs partners), coordinate communications, and reduce staff time spent searching across files.

If implemented, this should be done with a simple structure: define a consistent naming convention, required fields (name, email, phone, volunteer role interest), and a basic process for how new contacts get added and updated. This is intentionally not a “new system” recommendation; it is about getting maximum value out of a tool the Kitchen already has and trusts.

6.2 Recommendation 2: Unify Volunteer Scheduling and Reduce Manual Follow-up

The second recommendation is to unify volunteer scheduling into one process and reduce reliance on manual workarounds. Staff described using both SignUpGenius and a paper calendar for long-time volunteers, which creates parallel systems and reduces visibility into full coverage in one place.

In addition, staff noted that when larger groups sign up, they sometimes call ahead to confirm attendance because volunteer no-shows can directly impact meal service. While this follow-up is effective, it is time-consuming and depends on staff availability.

A realistic “keep it simple” improvement would be to standardize volunteer commitments through one scheduling workflow, even if the long-time volunteer group continues to be handled differently behind the scenes. At minimum, the goal is a consolidated view of expected coverage for the day. Practical options include moving recurring volunteers into a repeating sign-up pattern, or keeping the paper calendar but having one person enter that coverage into the same schedule view so staff can see the full picture without checking two places.

6.3 Recommendation 3: Improve Communication and Engagement with Younger Supporters

The third recommendation is to strengthen the organization’s ability to communicate with younger generations through more consistent digital outreach. Leadership identified a long-term sustainability issue: the organization is currently supported heavily by older donors and

volunteers, and they want to improve communication methods so younger community members can become future volunteers and donors.

This recommendation does not require a complex marketing transformation. A practical approach would be to create a consistent digital communication rhythm that aligns with their existing strengths, including donor relationships and storytelling. A simple plan could include: a short monthly email update, consistent social media posts tied to volunteer opportunities and impact, and basic audience segmentation using LGL once contacts are consolidated.

Leadership also mentioned exploring possible email-related integrations through their website vendor. If those tools are not a good fit, the organization could still implement a lightweight email platform that integrates with their existing contact management approach. The goal is not “more technology,” but clearer communication with the next generation of supporters.

6.4 Recommendation 4: Create Lightweight Metrics and Reporting That Preserve the Mission

The fourth recommendation is to develop minimal, low-burden reporting metrics that help with fundraising and board oversight while preserving the organization’s no-questions-asked service approach. Leadership noted that the Kitchen does not collect demographic or client-level data and often relies on best-guess estimates when funders ask who is served.

A balanced approach would be to focus on metrics that do not require collecting personal demographic information. Examples include meals served per day, estimated unique guests (if feasible), volunteer hours, donation pickup weights by partner source, and basic operational capacity indicators. This type of reporting would improve grant readiness and make it easier to communicate impact to funders without changing the organization into a data-heavy social service model.

This recommendation is also consistent with the organization’s emphasis on simplicity

and avoiding unnecessary administrative work. It is about choosing a small set of measures that can be tracked consistently with minimal disruption.

6.5 Recommendation 5: Plan for Hardware Refresh and Basic Security Continuity

The fifth recommendation is to create a simple plan for hardware replacement and basic security continuity. Staff indicated that most laptops are at least five years old, and while they work today, aging hardware increases the risk of downtime and replacement urgency later.

Staff also described relying on a mix of volunteers, board members, and an external IT contact for support. This is a strength, but it also means continuity depends on who is available and what knowledge is documented.

A “simple but strong” improvement would be to document a basic technology checklist: which devices exist, who uses them, replacement expectations, how passwords and account access are managed, and what happens when a device fails. Leadership also described a donor relationship model where specific needs (such as equipment upgrades) can sometimes be funded by key donors. A documented refresh plan makes it easier to ask for those targeted gifts when needed.

7. Conclusion

This IT Strategic Assessment shows that the Franciscan Kitchen’s technology environment is intentionally small and mission-focused, which is a good match for an organization with limited staff and a heavy reliance on volunteers. Leadership emphasized that the Kitchen’s mission is simple and that operations should remain as simple as possible while continuing to serve the community effectively.

At the same time, the stakeholder meeting identified several realistic improvement opportunities that do not require large investments or complex new systems. The most valuable near-term improvements focus on consolidating information into systems already in use (especially LGL), reducing duplicated volunteer scheduling processes, and strengthening digital communication to reach younger supporters.

Overall, the organization appears stable and functional today, but targeted process and technology improvements can reduce coordination burden, improve continuity, and strengthen long-term sustainability while staying consistent with the Kitchen's mission and capacity.

8. Appendices

8.1 Basis of Analysis

This assessment uses course frameworks from CIS discussions to connect the Franciscan Kitchen's mission, processes, and technology environment. The analysis focuses on strategic alignment, meaning technology choices should directly support mission delivery and should not add unnecessary administrative overhead. This is especially relevant in an organization with part-time staff and volunteer-driven operations.

The report also applies a governance and decision-rights lens. The Franciscan Kitchen has a board that meets regularly to review finances and operations, which provides oversight and helps set priorities. Recommendations were designed to be feasible within this governance model and realistic for an organization that does not have dedicated IT staff.

Finally, the report uses process analysis concepts (process mapping and bottleneck identification) by examining key workflows such as volunteer scheduling, donation intake, and

recordkeeping. The focus is on simplifying handoffs, reducing duplicate systems, and improving continuity rather than introducing complex automation.

8.2 Technology Inventory

The following inventory summarizes the technology environment described in Section 4.

Hardware and related systems:

Staff desktop (executive director), staff laptops (for other staff), donated printers/scanner, security camera system with monitoring screen, and an upgraded phone system.

Software and platforms:

Windows, Google Drive tools for files and lists, SignUpGenius for volunteer scheduling, Little Green Light (LGL) for donor management and contact tracking, QuickBooks for accounting, and Square for event payments. The website is hosted through eCatholic, and donation receipts were referenced as coming from BluePay.

8.3 Top 10 Technology Issues

This appendix repeats the “Top 10 Technology Issues” identified in Section 5.2 for reference and prioritization.

1. Limited service demographic data for external funders.
2. Volunteer scheduling split across SignUpGenius and a paper calendar.
3. Volunteer attendance reliability risk requiring manual follow-up.
4. Volunteer and contact lists distributed across Google Drive.
5. LGL is helpful but not yet used to full capability and integration is still being worked out.
6. Inventory visibility depends heavily on key people rather than a shared system.
7. Donation intake is complex and tracked at a broad level rather than item-level detail.

8. Online donations and event payments involve multiple vendors (eCatholic, BluePay, Square).
9. Aging laptops increase future reliability and security risk.
10. IT support depends on volunteer availability and informal support paths.